

The Cursor Agent Triage Card

01 · THE 5 FAILURE CLASSES

01 Hallucination

Agent claims a tool, API, or function exists when it doesn't.

'I called the pricing service' -- it never did.

02 Context starvation

Missing file, stale rule, or unread contract. Agent fills the gap by guessing.

Invents a function shape the test doesn't expect.

03 Plan drift

Loses the goal mid-loop. Edits the wrong files. Solves the wrong problem.

Touches main.py when only discounts.py was asked.

04 Tool / MCP misfire

Wrong arguments, wrong server, silent retry on error.

Calls MCP with bad JSON, falls back to a hardcoded value.

05 Verification gap

Claims "done" without proof. No tests run, no output pasted.

'All tests pass [OK]' -- pytest was never invoked.

02 · THE 3-QUESTION TRIAGE · THE THREE-LAYERS SPINE

The Three-Layers Framework

Where Cursor agent failures actually live

MODEL

raw intelligence

~5%

ORCHESTRATION

planning + loops

~25%

CONTEXT

files, rules, tools

~70%

Rule: Diagnose top-down. Fix bottom-up.

Ask these 3 questions, in order

Walk DOWN the stack. Stop at the first NO.

Q1

Did the agent UNDERSTAND the task?

Re-read its plan, not its code. If the goal is wrong, everything below is wrong.
>> **Model layer**

Q2

Did it follow a SANE LOOP?

Plan, act, verify, report. Skipped verification? Looped forever? Retried silently?
>> **Orchestration layer**

Q3

Did it have the RIGHT CONTEXT?

Files in scope. Rules loaded. Tools available. Contracts read. This is where 70% live.
>> **Context layer**

03 · THE 4 PRE-PRODUCTION GUARDRAILS · ADD TODAY

01 Plan-then-Act

Require a written PLAN.md before any edit.

Goal · files to touch · files NOT to touch · tests.

02 Blast-radius limits

Allow-list the files & commands the agent may touch.

No rm, no force-push, no edits to /rules or /tests.

03 Verification gate

"Done" is forbidden until pytest exits 0 this turn.

Paste last 10 lines of output. Evidence, not claims.

04 Tool discipline

Echo MCP arguments. Surface errors. Never invent tools.

If a capability isn't in mcp.json — say so. Don't fake it.